

CIRQL — Build Plan

"An ocean of circles that never ends — you light it with real taps, glowing Wonders, and the friends in your Cirql."

CIRQL is the flagship: a persistent, magical, social world of concentric island-rings. You start at **The Hearth** and sail outward forever. This plan is the working guide — checkoff lists mirror the Linear project "**CIRQL — Flagship World**" (team CHR). **Scope of this pass:** "through the arcade beat" — a shippable playable slice; deeper social depth is Phase 2 at the bottom.

Progress log

- **M1 · The World & Movement — DONE & LIVE** (commit [b664883](#)). Walkable Hearth island: cottage, Wonders monolith, Ferra (NPC), Cirql lantern ring, movement, minimap, glow, interact → dialog/toast.
- **M2 · Identity & Persistence — DONE & LIVE** (commit [b09c79c](#)). Save/resume via the [cirql](#) game_progress key; first-run character creator (avatar moved into CIRQL) + "Look" re-edit; expanded avatar (hat styles, aura glow, companions, bigger palettes).
- **M3 · Quest System (backbone) — DONE & LIVE** (commit [32e4d9e](#)). Reusable registry (defs in code, progress in the [cirql](#) blob — no migration), objective model + chain, reward→sparks hook, objective tracker HUD, waypoint chevron + minimap dot, NPC give-via-dialog, quest-log panel.
- **Feel/UX polish — DONE & LIVE:** smooth-text overlay (readable UI on phones, [e3905ee](#)), full-bleed responsive viewport + 4-direction facing ([d9e2b27](#)), full-screen immersive layout + tap-absorbing control tray ([a2e69e4](#)), and the **full-screen sea chart** (tap the minimap; [3dd6f46](#), CHR-250).
- **M4 · First Quest Chain (onboarding) — DONE & LIVE** (commit [677bf40](#)). Find Your Feet → The Lantern Path → The CirqlCade Door, auto-chaining; first-run auto-accepts quest 1.
- **Brand:** flagship wordmark **CIRQLVERSE** (CIRQL white + VERSE half-size violet); the in-world arcade building renamed **CirqlCade** with a cosmic mystery-dome roof.
- **M5 · CirqlCade (in-world arcade) — DONE & LIVE** (commit [26eead2](#)). Enter CirqlCade → a hall of all ~57 live cabinets (from the registry); tap one → it plays **embedded in an iframe over /cirql** (never leaves CIRQLVERSE); "← CirqlCade" exits to the hall and the game's own /arcade back-link is caught + routed back; **a spark a play** on exit. Verified end-to-end (0 errors, tsc clean).
- **M6 · Sparks Economy & Your Cirql — DONE & LIVE** (commits [9f4c0e4](#), [df76f4a](#)). World Energy meter, your-Cirql lanterns + Cirql panel (Invite + "share a light"), capped spark-a-play, and **spend-sparks cosmetics** (buy-in-place in the creator; owned persists). **Only CHR-245 (retire the platform-wide arcade reward system) remains — intentionally deferred** to its own careful pass (big blast radius).
- **Next up: M7 · Playable Slice Hardening.**
- **Roadmap grew (owner brainstorm):** added **M8 Social/chat**, **M9 Campaigns & Party Finder**, **M10 Endless content engines** (procedural rings, quest templates, daily/seasonal, Myst-style puzzles), **M11 Depth & Delight wishlist** (Hearth décor+visiting, emotes, tapped-shops→landmarks, sailing-as-journey, jump). Positioning: **Balanced**.

Locked decisions (owner, 2026-07-06 — "ALL IN")

- **The Wonders** = the 50 arcade cabinets folded IN-WORLD as enchanted monoliths you *attune* to (press E → the cabinet opens as an in-world overlay; you never leave CIRQL). Found on the first quest, which is the movement tutorial.
- **One currency: SPARKS.** All rewards come out of the arcade's own system and unify under sparks. **Earn** ~a spark a play + a small capped performance bonus (and, Phase 2, real-world taps). **Spend** in an in-CIRQL reward catalog (avatar cosmetics, Hearth décor, perks). Sparks are the games *and* in-platform reward.
- **Avatar lives in CIRQL.** The chooser moves out of the arcade into a **first-run character-creation** step (sign-up / first play), with **lots more fun choices** — auras/glows, patterns, hats/crowns, companions — despite the circular art. Free at creation + spark-unlockable extras.
- **Your Cirql** = your friends, shown as **lanterns lighting your Hearth** (dim → beacon). Grown by **meeting people in-world** ("share a light", a chat-free beacon) **and inviting real friends** (rewarded-referral, reskinned as light).
- **Chat is channelled** so the feed never jams: **Global** (ambient) · **Party/Group** (campaigns & friends) · **Direct Messages**. Needs the live presence layer, so it becomes milestone **M8**.
- **Look:** supersampled 16-bit RetroEngine + the neon glow-up kit — "modern-but-16-bit". Approved 5-frame lookbook + playable in-game mockup.

Completed — reusable foundations (M0)

- ✓ [/town](#) websocket prototype — presence + move + chat proven (CHR-211)
- ✓ RetroEngine, supersampled (SS=1.5) (CHR-212)

- ✓ 50 arcade cabinets + registry + arcade-shell — become the Wonders (CHR-213)
- ✓ Avatars + shared joystick + `game_progress` save table (CHR-214)

M1 · The World & Movement — DONE

- ✓ `/cirql` route + lazy page scaffold (CHR-215)
- ✓ World engine: canvas render loop + camera (CHR-216)
- ✓ Concentric-ring data model + ring configs (CHR-217)
- ✓ The Hearth (ring 0) authored map + props (CHR-218)
- ✓ Player movement: WASD + click + joystick + edge collision (CHR-219)
- ✓ Minimap: concentric rings + fog + player dot (CHR-220)
- ✓ Ambient neon polish (glow-up kit) (CHR-221)
- ✓ Full-screen sea chart (tap minimap to expand) (CHR-250)

M2 · Identity & Persistence — DONE

- ✓ Cirql state model + save/load endpoints (`cirql` key) (CHR-222)
- ✓ Load-on-enter + autosave + resume (CHR-223)
- ✓ Character creation on first entry — move avatar chooser into CIRQL (CHR-242)
- ✓ Expand avatar customization — more choices, fun, circle-friendly (CHR-243)

M3 · Quest System (reusable backbone) — DONE

- ✓ Schema/persistence: quest progress in the `cirql` state blob (no migration) (CHR-224)
- ✓ Quest registry + progress engine + reward→sparks hook (CHR-225)
- ✓ Client: quest log + objective tracker HUD (CHR-226)
- ✓ Client: NPC quest-givers + waypoint markers (CHR-227)

M4 · First Quest Chain (onboarding = movement tutorial) — DONE

- ✓ Quest 1 — "Find Your Feet" (teaches movement) (CHR-228)
- ✓ Quest 2 — "The Lantern Path" (teaches interact) (CHR-229)
- ✓ Quest 3 — "The Wonders Door" (find + enter the arcade) (CHR-230)
- ✓ First-run onboarding scripting hook (CHR-231)

M5 · CirqlCade (in-world arcade) — DONE

- ✓ CirqlCade hall — all live cabinets from the registry (CHR-232)
- ✓ Press-E launches a cabinet embedded over `/cirql` (iframe) (CHR-233)
- ✓ Return-to-world flow (catches the game's `/arcade` back) (CHR-234)
- ✓ Score → sparks (spark-a-play MVP; full normalization in M6) (CHR-235)

M6 · Sparks Economy & Your Cirql — CORE DONE

- ✓ Sparks currency + World Energy meter (CHR-236)
- ✓ Your Cirql: friends as lanterns around the Hearth (CHR-237)
- ✓ Invite-a-friend hook + "share a light" beacon stub (CHR-238)
- ✓ Earn sparks from play (spark-a-play + daily-capped) (CHR-244)
- ✓ Spend sparks: in-CIRQL cosmetics (buy-in-place in the creator) (CHR-246)
- Unify rewards → sparks (retire the arcade's separate reward system) (CHR-245) — deferred (platform-wide; own pass)

M7 · Playable Slice Hardening

- Full-loop smoke test (CHR-239)
- tsc clean + mobile pass + perf (CHR-240)
- Beta-test checklist entry + deploy (CHR-241)

M8 · Social — presence & chat channels

- ☐ Live presence in-world (`/ws/cirql` , room per ring) (CHR-247)
- ☐ Chat channel model: Global / Party / DM (CHR-248)
- ☐ Channel switcher UI + safety/moderation (CHR-249)

M9 · Campaigns & Party Finder (co-op)

- ☐ Campaign model: co-op multi-step quests (party-scoped) (CHR-251)
- ☐ Campaign Board: post / browse / join (+ new-player-friendly) (CHR-252)
- ☐ Party formation + shared waypoint + shared progress (CHR-253)
- ☐ Matchmaking requests + safety (tags, report/block) (CHR-254)

M10 · Endless content engines

- ☐ Procedural rings (infinite outward biomes) (CHR-255)
- ☐ Quest-template generator (infinite authored-feeling quests) (CHR-256)
- ☐ Daily + seasonal loops (rotating dailies, events, drops) (CHR-257)
- ☐ Myst-style puzzle quests / campaigns (CHR-258)

M11 · Depth & Delight (wishlist — owner-approved, unscheduled)

Positioning decision: **Balanced** (family-friendly / chat-free-first defaults + cosmetic-only + kindness mechanics, with fuller chat + competitive edges for older players).

- ☐ Hearth décor + visiting friends' Hearths (CHR-259)
- ☐ Emotes + chat-free expression (CHR-260)
- ☐ Tapped businesses become in-world landmarks (loyalty ↔ world) (CHR-261)
- ☐ Sailing as a mini-journey (interactive voyages) (CHR-262)
- ☐ Jump / hop movement (traversal + expression) (CHR-263)

Architecture notes (as built in M1)

- `client/src/game/cirql-world.ts` — declarative rings/props. **Add a ring = add a config here.** Ring 0 = The Hearth; outer rings stubbed (minimap fog) until Phase 2.
- `client/src/game/cirql-world-engine.ts` — `CirqlWorldEngine` extends `RetroEngine` . Host hooks for later milestones: `onInteract(kind,prop)` , `onLocalMove(ring,x,y)` (autosave), `getState()/applyState()` (persistence), `setStats()` (sparks / your-Cirql HUD), `toast()` . Interact key = **E** (and Space).
- `client/src/pages/cirql.tsx` — host page + joystick + E/run controls. In DEV the engine is on `window.__cirql` .

Gotchas to respect

- DB migrations:** `db:migrate` is broken on the shared Neon DB; `db:push` truncates. Apply additive DDL via a guarded script (quest tables, M3).
- Dev server:** `tsx` does not hot-reload server code — restart after server edits (kill the port-5000 PID if stuck). Client hot-reloads via Vite.
- `apiRequest` returns a raw `Response` — always `.json()` it.
- Cabinet back-buttons hardcoded** `/arcade` — override when a Wonder launches inside CIRQL (M5).
- Don't shadow RetroEngine base methods/fields** (`px` , `ring` , `last`) — world fields are `posX/posY/curRing` .
- Deploy:** push to `chr-5-7-phase0-run-locally` → Render auto-deploys (~2–4 min); confirm the new `/assets/*.js` bundle hash.

Phase 2 — deferred (after the arcade beat)

- Real-world tap → sparks bridge (the moat: a café tap widens the shared sea).
- Friends/parties depth — party up, sail together, co-op ring unlocks.
- Trading + inventories (both-confirm, anti-scam).
- More rings/biomes (Whisperwood, Glimmer Bazaar, outward forever) + docks/portals.
- Depth — quests beyond onboarding, light combat/monsters, seasonal drops.